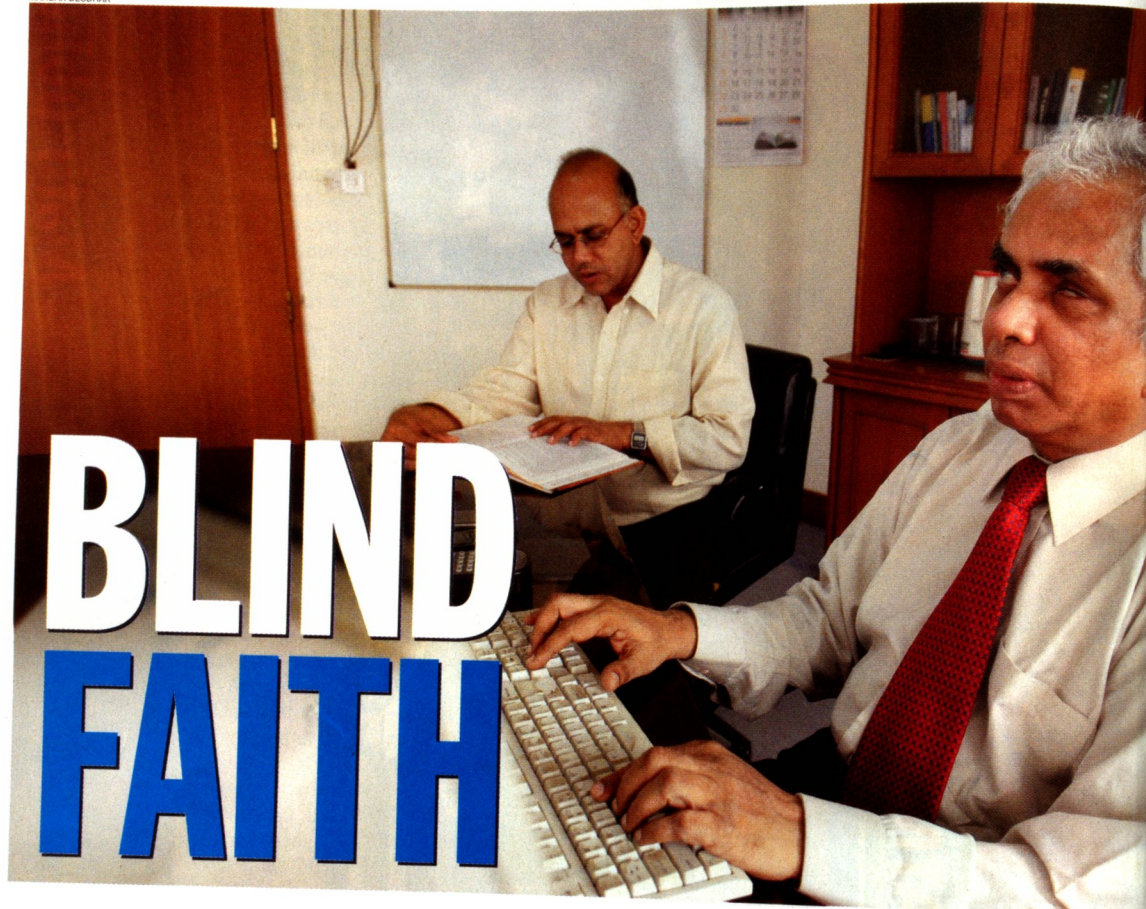


MANJAR DEODHAR



They have chosen not to stand and wait on the periphery of society. India's visually challenged are increasingly using technology to combat barriers at the workplace.

■ **By Malini Bhupta**

Nagraj More is passionate about reading, mountaineering and making films. When he is not resolving matters of the workers or designing training programmes for them, More is busy shooting short films that he will never see for himself because this deputy manager, HR-Lubes, with BPCL is congenitally blind. But being visually challenged has not affected More from doing any of the things that his other colleagues do at work. From checking his emails to replying to text messages on his mobile phone, he dexterously handles all his chores himself. Thanks to technologies like Job Access With Speech (JAWS), professionals like More are able to carry on their daily

activities just like any other professional.

From times when the visually challenged could dream of becoming nothing but a telephone operator, screen-reading software has given wings to ambitions of people like More. He says, "Thanks to assistive technologies like JAWS and optimal character recogniser, I can read everything and carry on with my daily functions without any trouble. I have even made two films for the sales staff at our multimedia studio."

He is not an exception. With more and more companies looking at physically challenged candidates with an open mind, opportunities are opening up for this segment. While many Indian companies still merely fulfil their corporate social responsibility duty by hiring such professionals, multinationals in India have a far more open approach towards these professionals because they follow inclusive policies, which give equal opportunity to people with disabilities. IBM, for instance, is actively involved in enabling the workplace for people with disabilities. The company actively removes barriers, both physical as well as technical, so that